



SCHOOL MISSION STATEMENT

LADY GREY ARTS ACADEMY

Regulatory Alignment & Authority	Details & Specifications
National Legislative Basis	Section 20(1)(c) of South African Schools Act, 1996 (Act No. 84 of 1996)
Provincial Governance Directives	Eastern Cape Department of Education Curriculum & School Governance Directives
Institutional Juristic Status	Lady Grey Arts Academy (EMIS: 200600985)
Core Educational Mandate	Whole School Development, Academic Excellence & Specialized Creative and Performing Arts
Adoption & Custodianship	School Governing Body (SGB) & School Management Team (SMT)

LEGAL NOTICE: This school mission statement is an official statutory and regulatory instrument drafted, adopted, and promulgated by the School Governing Body in terms of Section 20(1)(c) of the South African Schools Act, 1996 (Act No. 84 of 1996). This document aligns fully with the Constitution of the Republic of South Africa, 1996 (Act No. 108 of 1996), the National Education Policy Act, 1996 (Act No. 27 of 1996), and applicable provincial education legislation and governance directives. All members of the School Governing Body, School Management Team, educators, administrative and support staff, learners, and parents/guardians are legally bound by and subject to the provisions herein.

The Lady Grey Arts Academy is a Section 21 Public School, offering specialised education in the performing- and visual arts to students from all backgrounds and cultures in the more remote parts of the rural areas of South Africa - a true reflection of the South African “Rainbow Nation”. The Academy’s horizons in all educational respects are ever expanding to meet the needs of the young people of today, focusing especially on the development of artistic talent and skills.

1. OUR VISION

The Lady Grey Arts Academy will be a dynamic nationally and internationally known Arts school which produces graduate students who can make a critical and constructive contribution to society. Here the holistic development of every learner is developed and potential is turned into excellence.

2. OUR MISSION

The Lady Grey Arts Academy (LGAA) is an educational institution of excellence dedicated to the holistic development of young adults within a disciplined and nurturing environment. Guided by specialist educators, we use engaging, integrated learning methods designed to ignite learners’ imaginations and cultivate innovative problem-solving skills. Rooted in the belief that the arts are vital to human growth, our approach actively stimulates creativity, passion, and inventiveness in every student.

As a leading South African focus school for creative culture, LGAA continues to expand its international affiliations while deeply enriching local communities. We shape the unique character and identity of our learners through dynamic, multi-disciplinary approaches that bridge artistic expression with technological innovation. In doing so, we ensure that arts education remains accessible, inclusive, and deeply meaningful for the next generation.

3. OUR CORE VALUES

Respect, Honesty, Accountability, Excellence, Ubuntu

4. BACKGROUND AND BRIEF HISTORY

Founded in the Eastern Cape Province of South Africa in 1996, the Lady Grey Arts Academy is tucked away in the Southern Drakensberg Mountains in the quaint town of Lady Grey. Following the political changes of 1994, a severe drought situation and the depopulation of the small rural town Lady Grey, the School Governing Body at that time had to implement drastic measures to ensure the future of the town as well as the well-being of its community. A decision was made that would change the former David Ross Primary School to a completely new undertaking - that of an Art and Music School.

Christian ethos prevailed and, in a changing society, the Academy's boundaries have long since expanded to welcome pupils from all backgrounds and cultures. The Academy is indeed a true reflection of the South African "Rainbow Nation", offering specialised education in the Arts to pupils from the more remote parts of the rural areas of South Africa.

To assist in this venture, a visit was paid to the associate-director and conductor of the Drakensberg Boys' Choir School, Botes Gresse, who at that time had indicated a possible career change. He decided to take on the challenge and commenced his duties as music teacher in 1996 at, what was then known as the Witteberg Academy of Art and Music. In January 1997 Botes Gresse took over the reigns as headmaster of the school.

Nineteen-ninety-seven proved to be a watershed year in the school's history. Not only were more arts disciplines introduced as part of the official curriculum; a new school logo and uniform was approved and the name of the school changed to the Lady Grey Arts Academy. Since then, all five art subjects (Dance Studies, Design, Dramatic Arts, Music Studies and Visual Arts) form part of the curriculum.

The Academy very soon reached the status of a combined Primary and Secondary school with its first Grade 12 Class in 2000. The number of pupils has grown from 73 in 1996 to the current 375.

Another very important decision was also taken during 1997: the school would not be managed as an elitist institution, but would rather strive towards the development of the talents and artistic skills of any student who shows an interest or talent in the visual or performing arts, including the many talented youngsters in the rural parts of the Eastern Cape. Although this decision marked the beginning of a continuous financial struggle to make ends meet, it has proven to be beneficial to several previously disadvantaged youngsters who have found their passion, a large number of whom have managed to turn their passion into a successful career, living their dreams.

5. CURRENT SITUATION

5.1 ENROLMENT

The number of pupils has grown steadily from the 73 in 1996. There are currently 375 students registered at the school, ranging from Grade R (4 years old) to Grade 12 (19 years). Ninety of these students can be accommodated in the Excelsior Hostel. Most of the remaining students commute from surrounding towns, while some stay in private boarding houses in town.

5.2 ACTIVITIES

At the Lady Grey Arts Academy we believe, as Plato suggested, that artistic activity is fundamental to the development of the whole person. We therefore offer, apart from the normal academic curriculum as specified by the Eastern Cape Education Department, specialised courses in Dramatic Arts, Dance Studies, Music, Visual Arts, Design as well as Film Studies and Sound and Lighting.

5.2.1 PERFORMING ARTS

The key to the success of the Academy lies in the unique approach of integrating the various Art Disciplines into a coherent Arts Production. The result is an exhilarating and fresh stage experience of song, dance and acting, all-in-one entertainment of a world class standard.

5.2.2 MUSIC

Participation in music activities forms an important part of the Academy. The music-making and appreciation of a music environment is further enriched by the presence of the ALTECH Concert Choir, and the Le Passiones Performing Arts Group, the flagship of the Academy. Formal and informal concerts take place in and outside the Academy.

Music as a subject includes History of Music (Classical, Jazz and Indigenous Music), Harmony, Music Analysis and Aural Development. Music appreciation for school Grades 1 – 9 forms part of the Arts and Culture curriculum and includes basic voice training, musical knowledge and percussion playing.

5.2.3 DANCE STUDIES

Dance comprises two modules - Practical (Ballet, Contemporary and African Dance) and Theory (Health and Anatomy, Dance History and Music). Productions provide learners with a scope to be choreographed in all these dance styles, as well as Spanish Dance, Jazz, Tap Dancing and Modern Dance.

External examinations are done in Ballet, Contemporary Dance and African Dance, which ensure that an international standard is maintained.

5.2.4 DRAMATIC ARTS

Drama plays a key role in the life of the Academy, both in the curriculum and as a performing art. The range of plays and productions allows pupils to express their acting, dancing, singing and musical talents, or to become involved in the highly ambitious and technically advanced work behind the scenes. Pupils gain self-confidence through verbal and non-verbal communication skills. These skills empower them to follow a career in communication, marketing, public relations, film and television, theatre and education. The subject involves two components - Practical Productions (stage- and film work) and Theory (History, Play Analysis, Stagecraft, Sound, Lighting, Costumes, Make-up, Aspects of Speech and Practical Research). Pupils are exposed to a wide variety of theatrical and acting styles through regular rehearsals and productions.

5.2.5 VISUAL ARTS AND DESIGN

The Visual Art and Design Department allows for the optimum growth and creative expression of each pupil, promoting an awareness and sensitivity within the development of each age group. Pupils are encouraged to express personal preferences and experiences. The Academy is only too aware of the importance of Art in education and indeed within an integrated school curriculum.

The importance of organisation, discipline, order and logic in creative expression is emphasised, but practical skills are never neglected. These enable the pupils to explore various techniques, tools and materials.

In the Primary School the foundation is laid in basic, formal elements of Art, namely line, tone, colour, texture, form and space in two- and three dimensional expressions. In the senior classes the art pupils prepare and compile portfolios for further tertiary education or are empowered to create works of Art for the commercial market.

5.2.6 LADY GREY PASSION PLAY

In 2002 the Lady Grey Arts Academy and the Church Congregations of Lady Grey joined forces in the creation of an epic production of Christ's Passion. This annual event includes a cast of 160 speaking characters as well as a chorus, choir, troupe of dancers and live visual artists, and is presented over a period of three days during the Easter Weekend. This is a unique production on the African Continent, now heralded as the "Oberammergau" of South Africa and one of the many highlights on the annual calendar of the Academy. Sadly this production is no longer happening. The last Passion Play was in 2022.

5.2.7 PRE-SCHOOL PRODUCTION

All the students in pre-school take part in a performance during their annual "graduation ceremony".

5.2.8 JUNIOR PRODUCTION (GRADE 1 – 6) AND INTERMEDIATE PRODUCTION (GRADE 7 – 9)

All students from Grade 1 to Grade 9 are encouraged to participate in these annual productions, which include music, dance and drama. Preparation for the productions takes place during the creative arts periods and are performed during the school's cultural day in September.

Apart from group performances by the various classes, talented individuals are also given an opportunity to perform.

5.2.9 MUSICAL / ANNUAL CONCERT (GRADE 9 – 12)

Senior students are involved in either an annual concert, featuring highlights from the year's performances, or a musical during October.

5.2.10 SWEDISH EXCHANGE PROGRAMME

In 2006 the foundation was laid for one of the most exciting projects ever embarked upon by the Lady Grey Arts Academy.

After a visit by a Swedish delegation to the Lady Grey Arts Academy in March 2006, and a subsequent visit by the principal of the Academy to Stockholm, an exchange programme between the Academy and the Kultutama Gröndskola was established. Students from various ages from both schools, accompanied by two staff members, are annually selected to participate in this exchange programme of four weeks. Students and staff from Kultutama usually visit Lady Grey during the Passion Play period, while the visit by members of the Academy takes place between September and November.

The exchange programme commenced in April 2007 when the first Swedish group of students arrived in Lady Grey. Members of the Academy departed on 18 November 2007 for the first exchange to Sweden. Subsequently, successful exchanges have followed annually. During December 2012 a group of 20 performing arts students embarked on a successful Concert Tour, visiting Stockholm and Norrköping.

Both schools realise that this exchange programme is of immeasurable value to students from both countries, not only as far as their interest and love for the arts are concerned, but also for promoting people-to-people contact and a sharing of diverse cultures, particularly between the youth. The programme has a positive impact on students and educators and the ideal is to expand this exciting project as far as possible.

5.2.11 NAB'UBOMI COMPETITION

Nab'Ubomi is an inter-school filmmaking competition which introduces young people in the Eastern Cape to the media of film and television production. Opening doors to new career possibilities, it facilitates the discovery and development of talented senior high school students by allowing access to a creative world largely inaccessible to the vast majority of South African youth.

The Competition involves Grade 11 learners who write short narrative screenplays and practice 'pitching' their film concepts as an oral presentation. Schools enter their top film concepts (script & oral presentation) for consideration by the Nab'Ubomi selection panel. The most promising scripts are chosen for further development and production. Successful writers direct their own films and at each school a team of learners is chosen to work on the film in the following roles: producer/ project manager; camera; sound; lighting; clapper; continuity; grip and script supervisor. Learners receive basic training on filming equipment during a weekend film camp and return to school to cast the actors; select locations; source props and costumes; plot and rehearse the scenes.

The Nab'Ubomi crew mentor and assist the learner crew to complete filming in just one day at each school. The films are edited based on continuity notes and the director's shot selection from filming. The Nab'Ubomi team returns to each participating school to screen the full series of short films for the whole school. The school screenings culminate in Awards Evening hosted by the Department of Education.

During 2008, 2009, 2010 and 2011 the scripts of students from the Lady Grey Arts Academy were selected for filming – making the Academy the only school to be selected as finalists for four consecutive years. At the 2010 prize giving ceremony, held in Port Elizabeth, the film of the Lady Grey Arts Academy was awarded 2 trophies, best Scene and best Sound Department, and was one of the nominees for Best Film at the Festival. The 2009 film won trophies for best director and best sound technician, as well as 6 certificates, including best crowd scene and best original sound track. The 2008 film was awarded with the prize for best director.

5.3 SPORT

The Lady Grey Arts Academy prides itself on providing a balanced education to its learners. Although sport is an optional activity for learners, it forms an important part of this balance. It promotes a healthy life style and helps to develop fitness and physical co-ordination. Learners participate in various sporting codes, as their specific academic and arts programmes allow.

During the summer months, learners are encouraged to participate in athletics. This is done with great success and the Academy is proud of the fact that we have been represented at Provincial level in athletics for the past 8 years, producing 3 athletes who participated at national level during the past 4 years. Rugby, soccer and netball is played at competitive level during the winter.

ADOPTION AND SIGN-OFF RESOLUTION

This School Mission Statement was formally accepted, approved, and signed at a meeting of the Governing Body of the Lady Grey Arts Academy.

SIGNATURE _____
NAME: _____
SGB CHAIRPERSON
DATE: _____

SIGNATURE _____
NAME: _____
SGB TREASURER
DATE: _____

SIGNATURE _____
NAME: _____
SCHOOL PRINCIPAL
DATE: _____

SIGNATURE _____
NAME: _____
SGB SECRETARY
DATE: _____